Sensor Identity Does Not Transfer: Revisiting Test-Time Adaptation for Cross-Building Human Activity Recognition

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ABSTRACT

Test-time adaptation (TTA) is an appealing answer to cross-building deployment in smart buildings: sensors run continuously, and labelled data from a new site never arrives. We evaluate three TTA methods developed for images (DIGA, PETAL and PeTTA) on human activity recognition and occupancy estimation across buildings, and find that how much they help is governed by the quality of the model they start from and not by the method. Occupancy estimation supplies the cleanest test, because the two transfer directions differ only in the quality of the source checkpoint: against a sound one no method improves and the normalisation-based ones lose ground, while against a checkpoint worse than chance the same methods gain 27 to 41 MCC points. Adaptation gain here measures source-model deficiency, not adaptation quality.

Reaching that comparison required measuring the cross-building gap itself. Sliding windows with unit stride cause adjacent samples to share nineteen of twenty timesteps, so a random train/validation split places a near-duplicate of almost every validation sample into training; under that split a source model reaches 0.998 macro-F_1, and grouped by recording day it reaches 0.53. The window definition makes almost no difference to this: the inflation comes from the split. Features matter as much. The 106 per-sensor features that dominate the usual design score *below* stratified-random guessing on the target in both directions, because a given sensor index is a different physical device in each building. With causal windows that an online system can compute, and thirteen window-level summary statistics that name no sensor, source and target macro-F_1 are 0.534 and 0.447 in one transfer direction and 0.454 and 0.307 in the reverse, a gap of 9 to 15 points instead of 83. One pattern recurs across every design choice we varied (which features, how long the window, how much temporal context) and in both transfer directions: the configuration that validates best in-domain transfers worst. On this data, selecting a model by in-domain accuracy selects the worst one to deploy elsewhere; whether that holds beyond these two apartments is untested.

Against that baseline the three methods behave differently, and each result traces to a specific published equation, not to our port. PETAL's coefficient weights the likelihood, so the value selected by tuning on target labels removes the learning signal entirely. PeTTA gates its update rate on a Mahalanobis distance summed over 64 embedding dimensions; across buildings that sum is large enough that the gate saturates and the teacher stops updating. DIGA does help, by 1.7 macro-F_1 points with a bootstrap interval excluding zero, but only with hyperparameters retuned on target labels, and across its full published grid the sign of the effect follows the source checkpoint rather than the setting. Our conclusion is not that TTA fails in smart buildings, but that it was being asked to repair a problem largely created by evaluation and feature design.

1. Introduction

Buildings account for a large share of global energy demand, and occupancy-aware control of HVAC and lighting is one of the more direct levers available for reducing it [1, 2]. Human activity recognition (HAR) and occupancy estimation (OE) supply the signal such control needs [3, 4]. Both are learned from sensor traces, and both face the same obstacle when a model trained in one building is installed in another: room layouts differ, sensors sit in different places, and occupants keep different routines [6, 7]. A model that works in the building where it was trained often does not work in the next one.

Test-time adaptation addresses this without requiring labels from the new site. A frozen source model updates itself online from the unlabelled stream it is already processing, with no access to source data and no target annotation [8]. For buildings, where sensors are always on and manual annotation is impractical, the fit is obvious. The method family has matured quickly on images: DIGA [9] adapts normalisation statistics and class prototypes without gradients, PETAL [10] treats lifelong adaptation as probabilistic inference, and PeTTA [11] stabilises adaptation when environments recur. Whether their assumptions survive the move to one-dimensional sensor data is an open question, and the one we set out to answer.

Answering it requires first establishing that the quantity these methods are asked to reduce is measured soundly, and we began there. Implementing the standard pipeline reproduces the picture the literature reports: a source model validating near 0.99 macro-F_1 and scoring 0.16 on a second apartment, a drop that reads as severe domain shift. That measurement does not survive scrutiny. Features are computed over sliding windows with unit stride, so consecutive samples share 19 of their 20 timesteps, and a random train/validation split places a 95%-identical copy of nearly every validation sample into training. We isolate the effect by varying the window definition and the split independently:

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the window moves source validation by under two points, the split moves it by forty-six. Grouping by recording day, a one-line change, gives 0.53 and leaves the target number essentially untouched. The gap that motivates this literature is therefore substantially smaller than reported, and the remainder of this paper measures both domains under the same protocol.

Once the protocol is fixed, the picture changes in a way that is more interesting than the original. Most of the remaining gap is attributable not to some irreducible property of cross-building transfer but to the features themselves. The conventional design devotes 106 of its 135 dimensions to per-sensor statistics, and those features are actively harmful across buildings: used alone they score below chance in both transfer directions, because `sensor_id_100` is a different physical device in each apartment. A model built from thirteen layout-invariant window statistics transfers far better while validating slightly worse in-domain.

That inversion is the central finding of this paper, and it is not confined to the choice of features. We observed it four more times, in both transfer directions: longer windows validate better and transfer worse; added temporal context does the same; and in the reverse direction the conventional feature vector attains the best source-validation score of any configuration we tried and the worst target score, below chance. The practical consequence is immediate and uncomfortable. Choosing a checkpoint by in-domain validation, the ordinary thing to do, systematically picks the model that will perform worst in the next building.

What remains for adaptation to do is correspondingly small, and the three methods divide cleanly. One helps a little. Two do not run at all, and in both cases the reason is specific, mechanical, and traceable to an equation in the original paper rather than to our implementation.

Our contributions are as follows.

- **In-domain fit anti-correlates with cross-building transfer**, shown across feature sets, window length and temporal context, in both transfer directions (Sections 6.2 and 6.4). Per-sensor features, which drive most of the effect, score below stratified-random on the target either way.
- **Adaptation gain measures source-model deficiency, not adaptation quality.** On cross-office occupancy estimation the two transfer directions differ only in the quality of the source checkpoint: against a sound one no method improves, against one worse than chance the same methods gain 27 to 41 MCC points. PETAL and PeTTA reproduce source predictions in both (Section 6.9).
- **Three mechanisms by which image-domain assumptions break on sensor data**, each tied to a published equation: PETAL's $\bar{\lambda}$ scales the likelihood, PeTTA's divergence signal saturates, and DIGA's advertised global hyperparameters do not transfer (Section 6.6).
- **A protocol error that accounts for most of the reported cross-building gap.** We isolate it by varying the window definition and the validation split independently. Causality and segmentation move source macro-F_1 by less than two points; the split moves it by forty-six (Section 6.1).
- **Causal features that are both deployable and better.** Windows centred on the labelled sample read five minutes into the future, contradicting the online premise of TTA. Replacing them with causal windows improves target macro-F_1 by 7.3 points. There is no trade-off to manage (Section 6.1).
- **A located ceiling.** Seven attempts to raise target performance beyond the deployable checkpoint are reported, six of which fail, including an unsupervised sensor-correspondence method given the advantage of offline access to the target stream (Sections 6.4 and 6.5).

Section 2 reviews domain adaptation and TTA for sensor data. Section 3 states the problem and the three methods. Section 4 describes our data handling, protocol and features. Sections 5 and 6 give the setup and results. Sections 7 and 8 discuss and conclude.

2. Related work

2.1. Domain adaptation in smart buildings

Cross-environment degradation in building sensor models is well documented, and the usual remedy is feature-level alignment using unlabelled target data gathered before deployment [3, 15, 4]. Open-set extensions handle activities present in the target but absent from source training [16, 17]. What these approaches share is an offline phase: target data must be collected and processed before the model goes live. A model arriving in a new building has none, annotating sensor streams is expensive, and taking a building management system offline to retrain is rarely acceptable. TTA exists to remove that phase.

2.2. Test-time adaptation and its assumptions

TTA adapts a pre-trained model during inference using only unlabelled target samples [8]. It is stricter than source-free domain adaptation [14], which permits repeated offline passes over the target set: TTA runs online, in a single pass, on samples as they arrive. TENT [12] minimises prediction entropy over batch normalisation parameters and assumes a stationary, i.i.d. test stream, both of which fail for building sensors, where distributions drift across the day and consecutive readings are correlated. Under class imbalance, entropy minimisation tends to reinforce the majority class, since confident low-entropy outputs are easiest to produce for frequent classes. CoTTA [13] extends TENT to continual settings with weight averaging and stochastic restoration, but relies on augmentation-averaged pseudo-labels, for which one-dimensional sensor data has no natural analogue.

The three methods we study were selected because their mechanisms are, at least in principle, modality-agnostic. DIGA [9] mixes source and instance normalisation statistics and adds a prototype classifier, computing no gradients at all. PETAL [10] places a posterior over source weights and derives a student–teacher objective with a source-posterior regulariser and Fisher-information-based restoration. PeTTA [11] targets recurring environments (Fig. 3), monitoring drift from the source model and modulating its adaptation rate to prevent collapse. Section 6.6 shows that each nonetheless embeds an assumption that fails here.

2.3. TTA for one-dimensional data

Outside vision, TTA is comparatively unexplored. Wang et al. [18] propose an optimisation-free method for wearable HAR using exponential-decay test-time normalisation. Related work studies source-free adaptation for EEG, which shares temporal correlation and channel heterogeneity with building sensors. None of this work addresses the combination we face: severe class imbalance, differing sensor layouts across sites, and recurring daily structure. Nor, to our knowledge, has any prior study examined how evaluation protocol and feature design interact with measured adaptation gains — which, as we show, dominates the comparison.

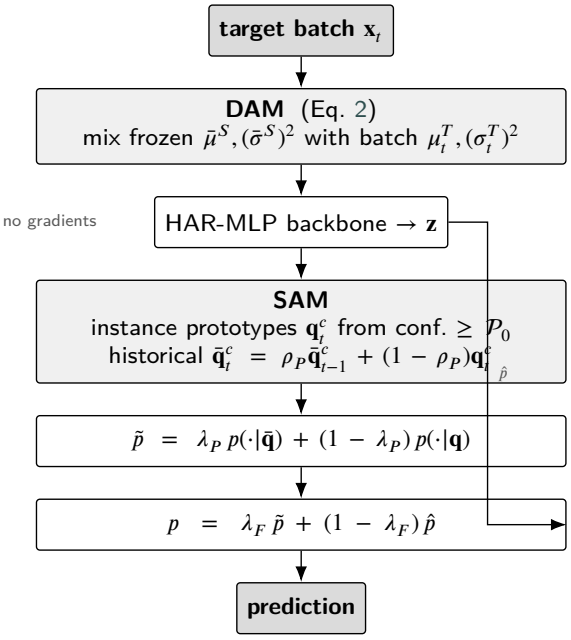


Figure 1: DIGA applied to the one-dimensional backbone. DAM mixes frozen source batch-normalisation statistics with the current batch's; SAM builds instance and historical prototypes and fuses their predictions with the parametric classifier. No gradient is computed anywhere in the loop.

3. Background

3.1. Problem formulation

A domain is a pair $\mathcal{D} = (\mathcal{X}, P(X))$ with feature space $\mathcal{X}$ and input marginal $P(X)$. A model f_θ is trained on a source domain $\mathcal{D}_S = (\mathcal{X}_S, P_S(X))$ from labelled data $\{(\mathbf{x}_n, y_n)\}_{n=1}^N$ and deployed on a target $\mathcal{D}_T$ with $P_S(X) \neq P_T(X)$ and no labels. At step t the model receives $\mathbf{x}_t \in \mathcal{X}_T$, predicts $\hat{y}_t = f_{\theta_t}(\mathbf{x}_t)$, and updates $\theta_{t-1} \to \theta_t$ without seeing a label:

$$\min_\theta \; \mathbb{E}_{\mathbf{x}_t \sim P_T(X)}\big[\mathcal{L}_{\text{TTA}}(f_\theta(\mathbf{x}_t))\big] + \mathcal{R}(\theta, \theta_0), \tag{1}$$

where θ_0 are the source parameters and $\mathcal{R}$ penalises drift.

Two constraints on Eq. 1 are usually left implicit and matter a great deal here. First, $f_{\theta_t}(\mathbf{x}_t)$ must be computable from information available at time t; a feature that reads future samples cannot be deployed. Second, any quantity used to define $\mathcal{X}$ (scalers, pruning masks, prototypes) must be estimable without target labels, and ideally without target data. Section 4 enforces both.

3.2. DIGA

DIGA [9], summarised in Fig. 1, combines a Distribution Adaptation Module (DAM) and a Semantic Adaptation Module (SAM), with no gradient computation. DAM mixes frozen source batch-normalisation statistics with those of the current batch:

$$\begin{aligned} \bar{\mu}_t^T &= \lambda_{\text{BN}} \bar{\mu}^S + (1-\lambda_{\text{BN}})\mu_t^T, \\ (\bar{\sigma}_t^T)^2 &= \lambda_{\text{BN}} (\bar{\sigma}^S)^2 + (1-\lambda_{\text{BN}})(\sigma_t^T)^2. \end{aligned} \tag{2}$$

SAM estimates per-class prototypes $\mathbf{q}_t^c$ from predictions above confidence $\mathcal{P}_0$, carries a historical copy by exponential moving average, $\bar{\mathbf{q}}_t^c = \rho_P \bar{\mathbf{q}}_{t-1}^c + (1-\rho_P)\mathbf{q}_t^c$, and builds *two* non-parametric classifiers which are mixed by λ_P before being fused with the parametric output by λ_F:

$$\tilde{p} = \lambda_P\, p(c|\mathbf{x}_t, \bar{\mathbf{q}}) + (1-\lambda_P)\, p(c|\mathbf{x}_t, \mathbf{q}), \tag{3}$$

$$p = \lambda_F\, \tilde{p} + (1-\lambda_F)\, \hat{p}. \tag{4}$$

We note that DIGA's Eq. 8 writes $p(c|\mathbf{x}, \mathbf{q}) \propto \exp(-\langle \mathbf{z}, \mathbf{q}_c \rangle)$. Read literally as an inner product this ranks the *least* similar prototype highest; we therefore treat $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ as a dissimilarity and report the effect of the alternatives in Section 6.6.

3.3. PETAL

PETAL [10], shown in Fig. 2, approximates the source posterior $q(\theta)$ by SWAG-diagonal and updates a student by ascending

$$\mathcal{L} = \log q(\theta) - \frac{\bar{\lambda}}{|\mathcal{B}|}\, \text{H}^{\text{xe}}(y', y \,|\, \bar{\mathbf{x}}), \qquad \theta_{t+1} = \theta_t + \eta \nabla_\theta \mathcal{L}, \tag{5}$$

with pseudo-labels y' from an EMA teacher and a Fisher-information criterion restoring unimportant parameters to θ_0. The role of $\bar{\lambda}$ in Eq. 5 is worth stating explicitly, because it is easy to misread: $\bar{\lambda}$ multiplies the *data* term, and the prior weight is fixed at unity. Setting $\bar{\lambda} = 0$ does not remove a regulariser; it removes the likelihood, leaving an update that does not depend on the target stream at all.

3.4. PeTTA

PeTTA [11] targets recurring environments. It senses divergence in feature space through a Mahalanobis distance

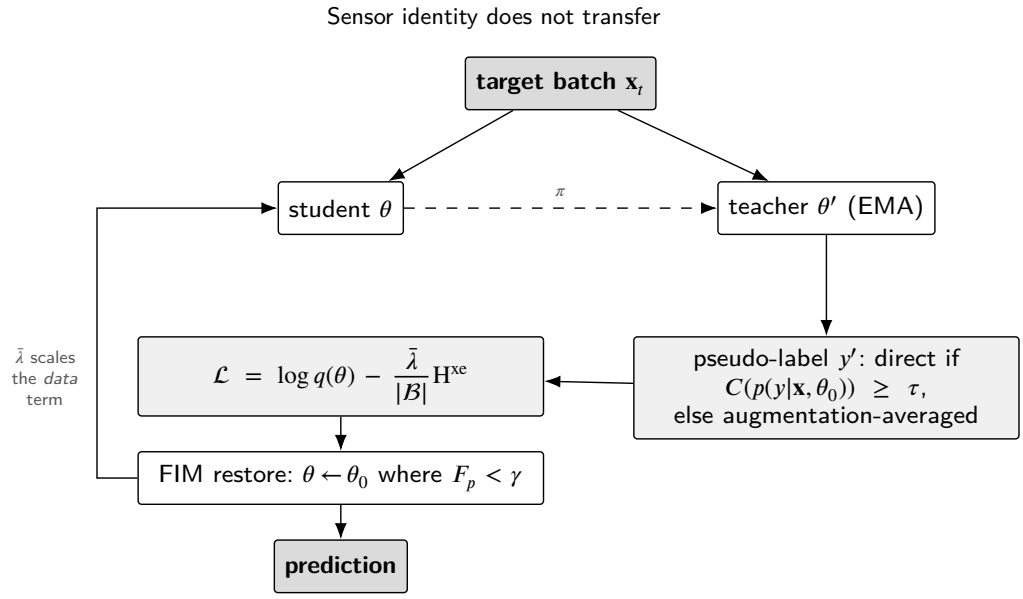


Figure 2: PETAL's student–teacher loop. The coefficient $\bar{\lambda}$ multiplies the cross-entropy, not the source-posterior term; Section 6.6 shows what follows when it is set to zero.

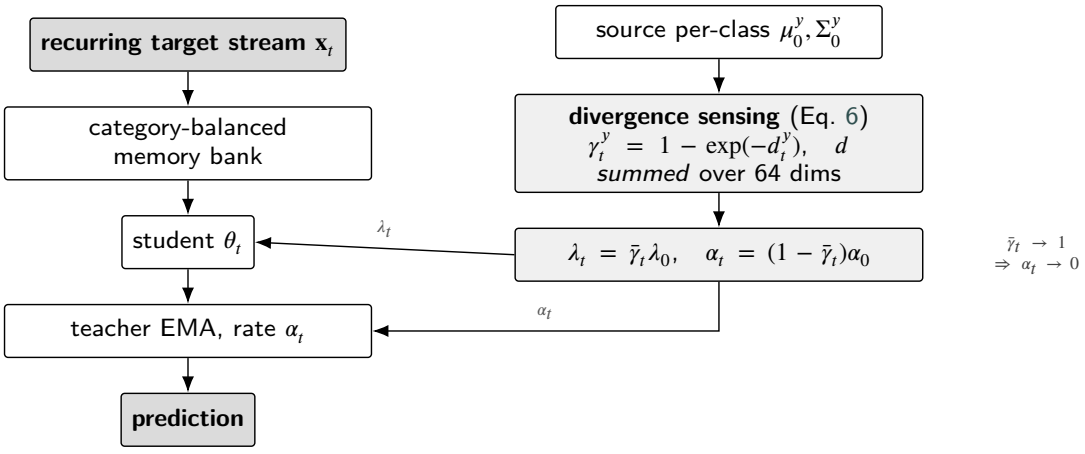


Figure 3: PeTTA for recurring streams. A single scalar $\bar{\gamma}_t$, derived from a Mahalanobis distance *summed* over the embedding dimension, sets both the regularisation weight and the teacher update rate. As $\bar{\gamma}_t \to 1$ the update rate goes to zero.

between per-class running means and their source counterparts,

$$\gamma_t^y = 1 - \exp\big(-(\hat{\mu}_t^y - \mu_0^y)^\top(\Sigma_0^y)^{-1}(\hat{\mu}_t^y - \mu_0^y)\big), \qquad (6)$$

and uses the batch average $\bar{\gamma}_t$ to set both the regularisation weight and the teacher update rate,

$$\lambda_t = \bar{\gamma}_t\lambda_0, \qquad \alpha_t = (1-\bar{\gamma}_t)\alpha_0. \qquad (7)$$

The quadratic form in Eq. 6 is a *sum* over embedding dimensions. Section 6.6 shows what that implies when the two domains are different buildings rather than corruptions of the same image.

4. Methodology

4.1. Windowing

Binary sensor activations are aggregated over windows of $W = 20$ consecutive timesteps at 30 s resolution, giving a 10-minute window per labelled sample. Two choices in this step are usually made implicitly, and we make both explicit because they turn out to matter.

Causality. A window may be *centred* on the labelled sample, spanning $[i - W/2, i + W/2]$, or *causal*, spanning $[i - W + 1, i]$. The centred form is common and reads five minutes into the future of every sample, which is incompatible with online deployment. We use causal windows throughout and quantify the difference in Section 6.1.

Segmentation. Windows must be truncated somewhere. Segmenting on *ground-truth activity changes* guarantees that no window straddles two activities, but hands the extractor the label transitions it is meant to predict. We segment instead on *recording continuity*: a new segment begins at a day change or a gap in the 30 s sampling. This uses no labels and is what a deployed system can determine. Windows are

truncated at segment starts instead of dropped, which is what an online system genuinely has after a gap.

4.2. Validation protocol

Because stride is one, adjacent samples share $W - 1$ of W timesteps. A random train/validation split therefore places a near-duplicate of nearly every validation sample into training, and the resulting score measures memorisation, not generalisation. We use **GroupKFold over `year_day`**: no recording day appears in both halves, which removes window overlap and same-day correlation together. All source model selection in this paper uses this protocol. Section 6.1 reports what each alternative gives.

4.3. Features

The conventional 135-dimensional vector comprises 106 per-sensor statistics (mean and standard deviation for each of the 53 shared sensors), five window-level activity statistics, 20 co-activation indicators for the most frequent sensor pairs in the source, and four cyclic time encodings. Of these, 126 are tied to *sensor identity*: the index 100 refers to a different physical device in each building, so a rule learned about it is not merely uninformative in the target but wrong.

We therefore evaluate a 13-dimensional **layout-invariant** set: nine window-level statistics of the per-timestep active-sensor count (mean, maximum, minimum, median, standard deviation, idle fraction, activation entropy, transition count, transition rate) and four cyclic encodings of time of day and day of week. Nothing in this set refers to which sensor fired. Appendix A reports a larger invariant set including a sorted activation profile and run-length structure; it does not improve on the thirteen.

Fig. 5 projects the engineered space onto its first two source principal components; the target occupies a displaced, compressed region.

All transforms are fitted on the source training split only. No target labels and no target statistics are used at any point in constructing the source model, so every configuration remains a legal TTA starting point.

4.4. Causal prediction smoothing

Activities persist for minutes while predictions are made per 30 s window. We apply a median filter over the last L predictions, never crossing a recording-segment boundary. This uses only past outputs and so remains deployable online. We report $L = 41$, selected on source data.

4.5. Stream protocol

Target data is divided into eight contiguous segments. *Non-recurring* streams visit each once; *recurring* streams make three passes in randomised order, repeated over three independent orderings. Target labels are withheld throughout adaptation and used only to score predictions afterwards.

4.6. What a method is allowed to know

Methods in this literature differ in what they require of the target building before they can produce a prediction,

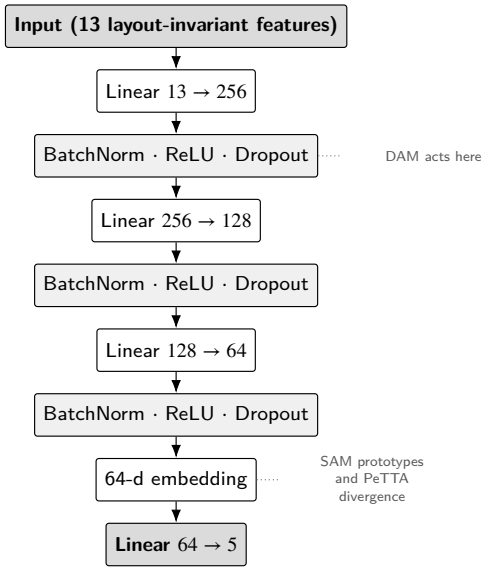


Figure 4: The classifier used throughout. Only the input width changes between feature sets; depth, widths and regularisation are held fixed so that comparisons isolate the features.

and the distinction is usually left implicit. We separate three levels.

Tier 1, no target data. Everything is estimated on the source. The model can be installed in a new building and run immediately. This is the setting test-time adaptation exists to serve.

Tier 2, unlabelled target data, offline. The full target distribution must be collected before deployment, though no labels are needed. This is source-free domain adaptation. It is a weaker requirement than labels but it reintroduces exactly the data-collection phase that motivates TTA.

Tier 3, target labels. Not deployable.

The distinction matters for what follows. The layout-invariant features used throughout this paper are tier 1: every transform is fitted on the source split alone, and the model needs nothing from the target building. Feature-shift pruning, by contrast, selects features by comparing source and target distributions, and is therefore tier 2 — unsupervised, but not deployable without a prior observation period. The hyperparameter selection discussed next is tier 3.

4.7. Hyperparameter selection

We report results using each method's *published* hyperparameters, and separately under target-label tuning where the two differ materially. Selecting on target labels is tier 3 by the distinction above and is not available in deployment. It is also not merely optimistic: Section 6.6 shows it selecting a configuration at which one method cannot adapt at all, and reporting the maximum of a distribution that is mostly negative for another. Where a label-free criterion is needed we use mean prediction entropy on the target stream, and

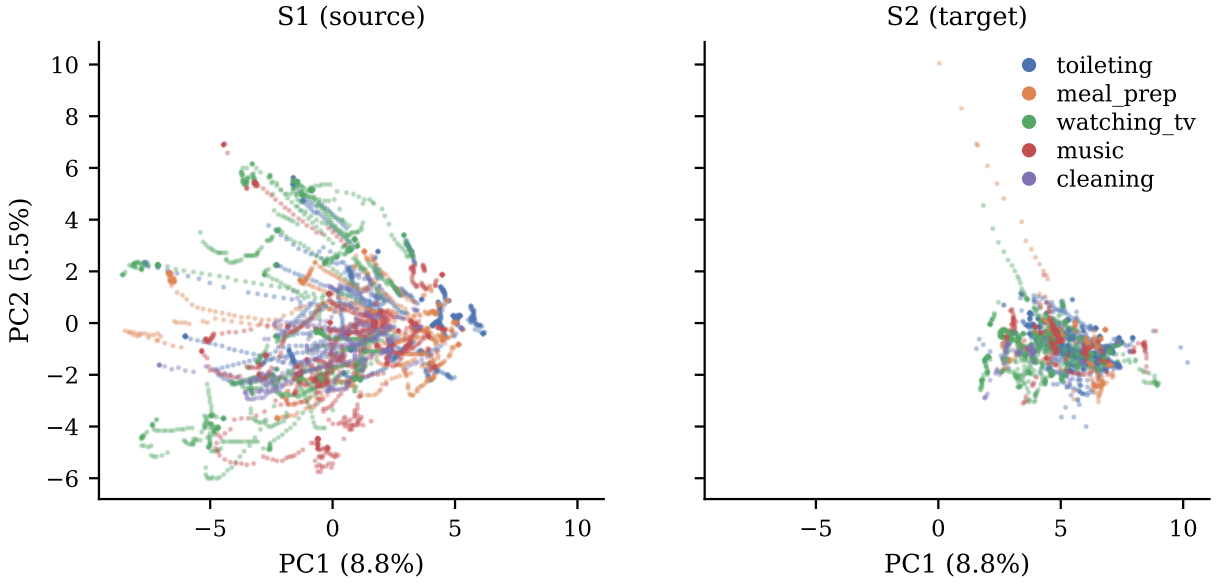


Figure 5: First two principal components of the causal engineered feature space, fitted on S1 and applied unchanged to S2. The target occupies a displaced and markedly compressed region, which is the shift the adaptation methods are asked to absorb.

report what it selects alongside the oracle value. So that no conclusion rests on a single setting, Section 6.8 searches each method's full published hyperparameter grid on the activity task in both directions, and Section 6.6 does the same for DIGA on occupancy.

5. Experimental setup

5.1. Datasets

HAR. The dataset of Tapia et al. [19] provides two single-occupant apartments, S1 and S2, instrumented with binary proximity sensors on household objects and recorded over roughly two weeks each (16 recording days here). S1 exposes 70 sensor columns and S2 exposes 75; feature engineering uses the 53 shared by both. Table 1 gives per-class counts. We evaluate both transfer directions.

Class names follow the source annotation (`toileting`, `meal_prep`, `watching_tv`, `music`, `cleaning`). We note this because the time-of-day distributions confirm them: activity code 65 occurs between 07:31 and 14:51 with a median of 11:34, which is consistent with `watching_tv` and not with a sleep-type label.

Occupancy. A private dataset collected from two university offices (H355 and H358) at the Grenoble Institute of Technology using CO_2 concentration sensors [5, 4]. The original annotation records occupancy counts (zero, one, two, three, more than three); we binarise to occupied / not occupied. The representation is nine engineered features produced by the originating pipeline; we use them as supplied and perform no further feature construction, so no target information enters through any step we control. Splits are 1145 / 200 source train / test and 822 / 150 target train / test, with roughly 78% / 22% class balance. Because the data is private, the released code reproduces the HAR results only.

5.2. Model

A three-layer MLP with batch normalisation, ReLU and dropout (Fig. 4), reducing the input to a 64-dimensional embedding followed by a five-class output layer. The architecture is held fixed across all feature sets so that comparisons isolate the features.

5.3. Metrics and baselines

We report accuracy, macro-F_1, MCC [20] and per-class F_1. macro-F_1 is the primary metric for HAR because it weights all activities equally, which matters when the target minority classes are small.

Chance baselines are reported in every table and are not optional here: several published figures for this transfer setting sit at or below them. On S2, constant-majority prediction gives accuracy 0.378 and macro-F_1 0.110, and stratified-random prediction gives accuracy 0.306 and macro-F_1 **0.200**. On S1 the stratified-random macro-F_1 is 0.200. For binary occupancy, always predicting "not occupied" gives accuracy 0.773, macro-F_1 0.436 and MCC 0.000.

Differences between methods are reported with 95% paired bootstrap confidence intervals over the target stream (2000 resamples), computed on the difference from source-only.

6. Results

6.1. Decomposing the source-domain fit

Establishing what the cross-building gap actually is requires measuring both domains under one protocol. Table 2 and Fig. 6 vary the window definition and the validation split independently, holding the feature arithmetic fixed, which separates the contribution of each.

A fully causal pipeline with no label-derived segmentation still validates at 0.9968 under a random split. The

Table 1
HAR dataset statistics. Class names follow the source annotation.

Split	Total	toileting	meal_prep	watching_tv	music	cleaning
S1	5031	1065	857	1598	1069	442
S2	3412	1266	417	1291	325	113

Table 2
Source-domain validation macro-F_1 by windowing policy and validation protocol (135 features, z-score, mean ± s.d. over 5 seeds). Reading down any column shows that the window definition is nearly irrelevant; reading across any row shows that the split is not.

Causality	Segmentation	Random 80/20	Blocked	Grouped by day
centred	activity labels	0.9984 ± 0.0009	0.4357 ± 0.0345	0.5287 ± 0.0067
centred	recording	0.9979 ± 0.0006	0.4571 ± 0.0451	0.5258 ± 0.0112
causal	activity labels	0.9975 ± 0.0021	0.4414 ± 0.0131	0.5261 ± 0.0084
causal	recording	0.9968 ± 0.0022	0.4608 ± 0.0209	0.5110 ± 0.0115

inflation is therefore attributable to window overlap under random splitting, not to the window definition. Grouping by recording day gives 0.51–0.53, and we treat that as the honest source-domain figure.

Causality nonetheless matters, in the opposite direction to what one might expect. Under a fixed training protocol, making features causal *improves* target transfer (Table 3): macro-F_1 rises from 0.1626 to 0.2356, with accuracy rising from 0.375 to 0.444. The deployable pipeline is also the better-transferring one, so nothing is traded away by adopting it.

6.2. Feature design

Table 4 sweeps feature subsets and source-fitted transforms on causal, recording-segmented features under GroupKFold selection.

Two observations. Per-sensor features alone reach 0.1484 macro-F_1, which is 5.1 points *below* stratified-random guessing. They are not weakly informative; they encode rules that are wrong in the target building. And the row with the best source-validation score (KS-pruned with rank-gauss, 0.6232) transfers at 0.3004, while the row that transfers best (0.4133) validates at 0.5341. In-domain fit and cross-building transfer pull in opposite directions, because what helps in-domain is precisely what is building-specific.

Table 5 and Fig. 7 repeat the comparison in both directions.

Both central claims replicate. Per-sensor features are below chance in both directions. The inversion is sharper in reverse: the conventional 135-d set has the best source-validation score of any row (0.5381) and the worst transfer (0.1583), itself 4.2 points below chance.

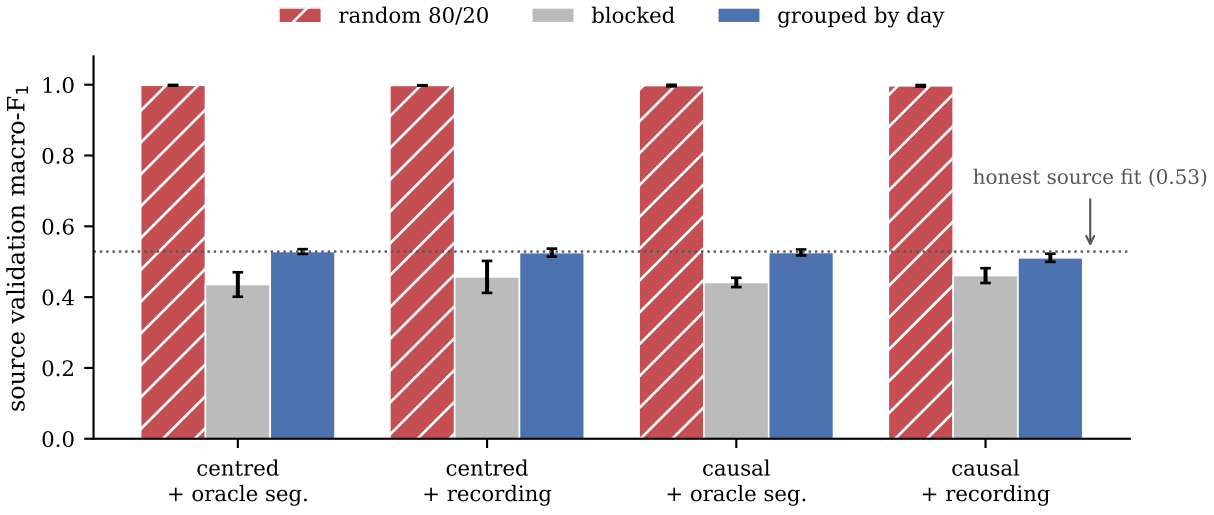


Figure 6: Source validation macro-F_1 under every combination of windowing policy and validation split (mean ± s.d. over 5 seeds). The hatched bars are the random split. Its height is independent of how the window is defined, which locates the inflation in the split rather than in the features.

Table 3
Target transfer (S1→S2) by windowing policy, 135 features, blocked-trained, mean over 5 seeds. Stratified-random macro-F_1 is 0.200.

Causality	Segmentation	macro-F_1	MCC	Accuracy
centred	activity labels	0.1626 ± 0.0125	0.0945	0.3753
centred	recording	0.1953 ± 0.0274	0.1327	0.3924
causal	activity labels	0.2344 ± 0.0232	0.2036	0.4533
causal	recording	$\mathbf{0.2356} \pm 0.0124$	0.1805	0.4440

Table 4
S1→S2 transfer by feature subset and source-fitted transform (causal features, GroupKFold over 16 days, 5 seeds). Stratified-random macro-F_1 is 0.200.

Feature set	Transform	d	Source-val macro-F_1	Target macro-F_1	Target MCC
All (conventional)	z-score	135	0.5083	0.2436	0.1682
All	rank-gauss	135	0.5890	0.3775	0.3144
KS-pruned 20%	z-score	108	0.5164	0.3130	0.2090
KS-pruned 20%	rank-gauss	108	**0.6232**	0.3004	0.2138
No per-sensor	z-score	29	0.5121	0.3561	0.2633
Global + temporal	z-score	9	0.5341	**0.4133**	**0.3490**
Global only	z-score	5	0.2914	0.2129	0.0970
Per-sensor only	z-score	106	0.3292	0.1484	0.0436

Table 5
Forward and reverse transfer under an identical protocol (causal features, GroupKFold over the source's days, causal smoothing $L = 41$). "Gap" is source-validation minus target macro-F_1, in points.

Direction	Feature set	d	Source-val	Target macro-F_1	MCC	Gap	vs. chance
S1→S2	Layout-invariant	13	0.5341	**0.4466**	0.3973	8.8	+24.7
S1→S2	All (conventional)	135	0.5133	0.2118	0.0976	30.2	+1.2
S1→S2	Per-sensor only	106	0.3248	0.1350	0.0123	19.0	**−6.5**
S1→S2	No per-sensor	29	0.5119	0.3630	0.2734	14.9	+16.3
S2→S1	Layout-invariant	13	0.4538	**0.3068**	0.2667	14.7	+10.7
S2→S1	All (conventional)	135	**0.5381**	0.1583	0.0332	38.0	**−4.2**
S2→S1	Per-sensor only	106	0.3668	0.1702	0.0553	19.7	**−3.0**
S2→S1	No per-sensor	29	0.4483	0.2271	0.1043	22.1	+2.7

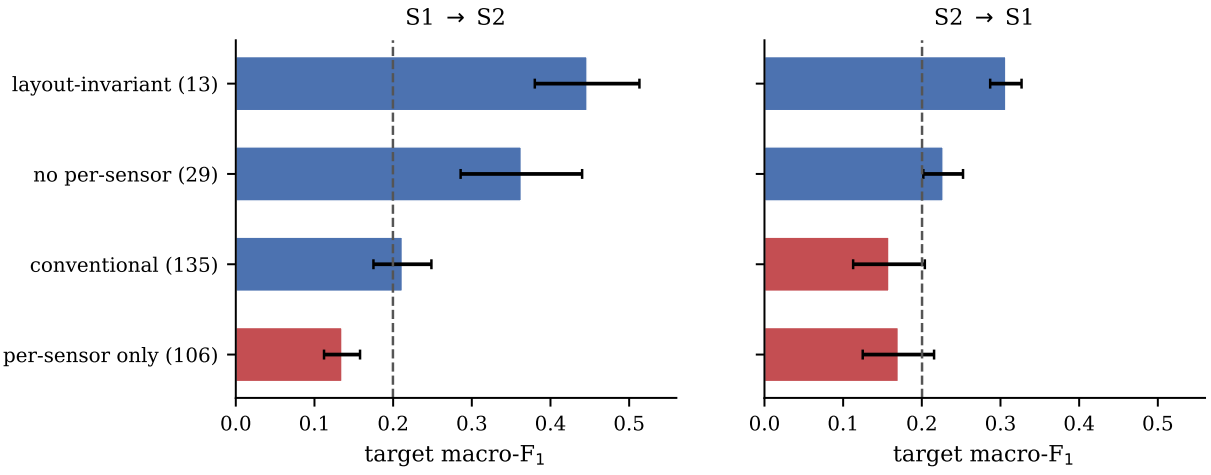


Figure 7: Target macro-F_1 by feature set in both transfer directions, with the stratified-random baseline marked (dashed). Bars falling short of it are shown in red. Per-sensor features are below chance in both directions; the conventional 135-d vector is below chance in one of them.

Table 6
TTA on the layout-invariant causal checkpoint (3 seeds; recurring streams additionally averaged over 3 randomised segment orderings). Stratified-random macro-F_1 is 0.200.

Method	Stream	Accuracy	macro-F_1	MCC
Source-only	non-recurring	0.6042 ± 0.013	0.4467 ± 0.029	0.4515 ± 0.033
AdaBN	non-recurring	0.3782 ± 0.011	0.2977 ± 0.005	0.1517 ± 0.013
TENT	non-recurring	0.3784 ± 0.011	0.2976 ± 0.005	0.1515 ± 0.013
DIGA	non-recurring	0.6045 ± 0.013	$\mathbf{0.4639} \pm 0.001$	$\mathbf{0.4739} \pm 0.009$
PETAL	non-recurring	0.6033 ± 0.008	0.4450 ± 0.023	0.4522 ± 0.026
Source-only	recurring	0.6042 ± 0.011	0.4467 ± 0.025	0.4515 ± 0.029
DIGA	recurring	$\mathbf{0.6073} \pm 0.010$	0.4625 ± 0.013	0.4700 ± 0.022
PETAL	recurring	0.6038 ± 0.010	0.4431 ± 0.020	0.4504 ± 0.026
PeTTA	recurring	0.6045 ± 0.011	0.4470 ± 0.025	0.4517 ± 0.029

Table 7
95% paired bootstrap confidence intervals on the difference from source-only (2000 resamples, same stream).

Method	Stream	Δmacro-F_1	ΔMCC
DIGA	non-recurring	[+0.0032, +0.0225]	[+0.0277, +0.0559]
DIGA	recurring	[+0.0146, +0.0311]	[+0.0387, +0.0633]
PETAL	non-recurring	[−0.0076, +0.0027]	[−0.0013, +0.0130]
PETAL	recurring	[−0.0087, +0.0015]	[−0.0067, +0.0067]
PeTTA	recurring	[−0.0007, +0.0006]	[−0.0009, +0.0011]
AdaBN	non-recurring	[−0.1754, −0.1379]	[−0.3046, −0.2500]
TENT	non-recurring	[−0.1756, −0.1383]	[−0.3050, −0.2503]

The gap is direction-dependent: 8.8 points forward and 14.7 reverse. The asymmetry has a visible cause rather than being noise. S2 is the weaker source: 3412 samples against 5031, with the hard classes much thinner (113 versus 442 for `cleaning`) — and training on the smaller, more imbalanced apartment lowers both sides of the comparison. We therefore state the result as a gap of 9 to 15 points instead of quoting the more favourable direction.

6.3. Test-time adaptation on the deployable checkpoint

Table 6 compares the methods on the deployable checkpoint.

In Table 7, DIGA is the only method whose interval excludes zero on the positive side, and the effect is small: +1.7 macro-F_1 and +2.2 MCC points. It is also contingent on how two under-specified steps of the method are implemented, which Section 6.7 quantifies. For comparison, the feature redesign is worth +17.0 macro-F_1 points before any adaptation runs. PETAL and PeTTA are statistically indistinguishable from the unadapted model. AdaBN and TENT are substantially *worse*, by around 17 points of macro-F_1, which is itself informative: adapting normalisation statistics helps when the source model is poor and hurts once the features are already distribution-robust.

Per-class F_1 (Table 8) shows four of five classes working. DIGA's prototype correction does what it is designed to do, lifting `meal_prep` by eight points at a cost of seven on `toileting`. `cleaning`, with 113 target samples, remains near zero for every method.

6.4. What does not move the result

Target performance is bounded by source performance: the deployable checkpoint validates at 0.534 in-domain and transfers at 0.447, a gap of under nine points. Raising the target therefore requires raising the source with features that still cross buildings. We report seven attempts, all negative, because together they locate the ceiling.

Two things are worth drawing out of Table 9.

First, the only attempt that helps in *both* transfer directions is the transition model, and it helps by less than a point (0.4466 → 0.4503 forward, 0.3068 → 0.3160 reverse). Its transition matrix is estimated on the source apartment and encodes nothing about sensors, only how often one activity follows another. That it transfers at all, while every attempt to extract more from the sensor stream does not, is consistent with the rest of this paper: what crosses buildings is behavioural regularity, not layout.

Second, and more importantly, several rows raise the source-validation score while lowering the target. Window length does (0.5611 at W=60 against 0.5341 at W=20), and so does temporal context (0.5414 for the TCN). Section 6.2 observed the same thing across feature sets. The pattern is general, and Section 7 returns to it.

6.5. Can the sensors be matched across buildings?

If per-sensor features fail only because index 100 denotes a different device in each apartment, the obvious repair is to estimate the correspondence. We tested this. Each sensor was described by a behavioural signature computed from

Table 8
Per-class F_1 on S2 (mean over seeds and orderings).

Method	toileting	meal_prep	watching_tv	music	cleaning
Source-only	0.551	0.493	0.746	0.435	0.009
DIGA	0.478	**0.572**	**0.766**	**0.468**	0.035
PETAL	0.550	0.474	0.746	0.440	0.014
PeTTA	0.552	0.494	0.746	0.434	0.009
AdaBN	0.365	0.310	0.482	0.275	0.056

Table 9
Attempts to raise target macro-F_1 beyond the 13-d causal checkpoint (S1→S2, same protocol throughout). Only causal smoothing and a source-estimated transition model help, and both marginally.

Attempt	What was varied	Source-val	Target macro-F_1
baseline	13-d, MLP, W=20, median L=41	0.5341	**0.4466**
richer invariant features	+ sorted profile, runs, multi-scale (60-d)	–	0.4188
class weighting	inverse-frequency weights	–	0.3852
network width	64–32 and 128–64	–	0.4297
classifier family	boosting, forests, linear	0.5230	0.4190
window length	$W \in \{10, 40, 60\}$	0.5611	0.4330
temporal context	stacked T=11, causal TCN T=21	0.5414	0.4111
sensor correspondence	unsupervised assignment (§6.5)	–	0.2227
transition model	source-estimated HMM, causal filtering	0.5341	0.4503

Table 10
Per-sensor features under four permutations, target macro-F_1. A correspondence that is real should transfer between halves of the target stream.

Permutation	Fitted half	Held-out half
identity (no matching)	0.0976	0.1744
learned signatures	0.0749	0.2348
greedy search on fitted half	**0.4174**	0.1738
random, 20 draws	—	0.1655 ± 0.050

unlabelled data: firing rate, burst-length statistics, a 24-bin diurnal profile, and an index-free summary of its co-activation neighbourhood. The two sensor sets were then matched by balanced assignment on signature distance.

To separate a real correspondence from overfitting, permutations were estimated on one half of the target stream and scored on the other.

A greedy search reaches 0.417 on the half it is fitted to and 0.174 on held-out data, indistinguishable from identity and from random. The signature-based assignment is inconsistent between halves. No permutation we could find transfers.

We note that this test is permissive: estimating a correspondence from the whole unlabelled target stream is offline source-free adaptation, not test-time adaptation (Section 4.6), so it has an advantage no deployable method would have. Failing under relaxed assumptions implies failing under strict ones.

The conclusion is stronger than the premise it tests. Per-sensor features do not fail because they are mislabelled across buildings. They fail because a sensor in one apartment has no counterpart in the other: rooms differ in shape, furniture sits elsewhere, and routines differ. Relabelling cannot recover information that was never shared.

6.6. Three mechanisms

A natural objection to what follows is that these methods were designed for images, so their failure on one-dimensional data is to be expected. The results do not support that reading, for three reasons.

First, the picture is not uniform. DIGA improves on the deployable checkpoint with a bootstrap interval excluding zero, and AdaBN, the simplest normalisation-based adaptation there is, gains 41.5 MCC points in one occupancy direction (Table 17). Methods built for images are evidently capable of helping on sensor data; whether they do turns out to depend on the source checkpoint and not on the modality.

Second, PETAL's failure has nothing to do with modality. Setting $\bar{\lambda} = 0$ deletes the likelihood term from Eq. 5 on any data, images included. What the move to sensor data changes is only which value a target-label search selects, and even that follows a statable condition, not the modality.

Third, PeTTA's failure is modality-related but not in the way the objection supposes. The method does not degrade gracefully; it stops entirely and silently, with losses that look unremarkable throughout. The mechanism is a scalar that reaches exactly 1 and multiplies the update rate by zero. Establishing that is the contribution, not the observation that image methods sometimes do worse elsewhere.

Table 11
PETAL as a function of $\bar{\lambda}$ (published parameterisation, Eq. 5). Source-only is macro-F_1 0.4641, MCC 0.4679. At $\bar{\lambda} = 0$ the weights still move, toward the SWAG mean, but the movement is independent of the target stream.

$\bar{\lambda}$	Drift from source	Predictions changed	macro-F_1	MCC
0.0	1.0021	24/3412	0.4676	0.4724
0.1	0.8118	26/3412	0.4650	0.4687
1.0	0.3580	17/3412	0.4643	0.4679
10.0	0.1688	22/3412	0.4637	0.4677

On implementation: each method is implemented from the equations and hyperparameters given in its source paper, and we report both the published settings and any retuned ones where they differ materially. For PeTTA we additionally confirmed the behaviour against the authors' released implementation, in which the divergence statistic is computed as a sum over the embedding dimension (`per_class_distance`), which is what produces the saturation reported below. The PETAL result requires no implementation at all: it follows from Algorithm 2 of the source paper.

PETAL: the coefficient scales the likelihood. As noted in Eq. 5, $\bar{\lambda}$ weights the data term. Table 11 sweeps it on the deployable checkpoint with a non-degenerate SWAG posterior.

The consequence is specific. On a source model that already outperforms what self-training produces, selecting $\bar{\lambda}$ by target-domain macro-F_1, a criterion in common use, prefers $\bar{\lambda} = 0$, the setting at which adaptation cannot occur. A reported null for PETAL obtained this way is a statement about the search procedure, not about the method.

The same selection rule distorts DIGA, in the opposite direction. Running its full published grid (Section 3, 64 configurations) on the occupancy task, every one of the 64 configurations *reduces* MCC relative to source-only once averaged over the three seeds: the median costs 1.0 point and the least damaging costs 0.7. Across individual runs, 83% are negative and the single best run gains 0.9 points, so a search reporting its own maximum over a grid and a seed can return a positive number drawn from a distribution with no positive mean. Selection on target labels returns exactly that maximum. A label-free rule, lowest mean prediction entropy on the target stream, selects the configuration costing 0.7 points, which is what a deployment would actually obtain. Section 6.8 repeats the exercise on the activity task and for all three methods.

PeTTA: the divergence signal saturates. Fig. 8 shows why. Eq. 6 sums over the 64-dimensional embedding. Across buildings that sum is large, $\exp(-d)$ underflows, and $\bar{\gamma}$ pins at unity, which by Eq. 7 sets α_t to zero and freezes the teacher. Table 12 measures it.

Normalising per dimension unfreezes the mechanism, and it still does not improve on the source model. An α floor alone does not help, because $\lambda_t = \bar{\gamma}\lambda_0$ is simultaneously pinned at maximum pull-back. We emphasise that saturation

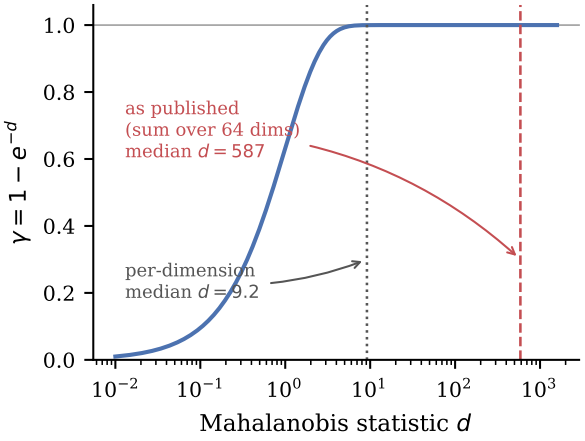


Figure 8: PeTTA's gating function. Because the Mahalanobis statistic is summed over 64 embedding dimensions, the cross-building median of 587 sits far inside the saturated region, giving $\bar{\gamma} = 1$ and an update rate of zero.

is a failure mode PeTTA's authors themselves document for ablated variants; what is new here is that it occurs for the full method when the domain gap is a change of building instead of an image corruption.

DIGA: published hyperparameters do not transfer. Table 13 crosses the two readings of DIGA's prototype similarity with two hyperparameter settings.

The literal inner-product reading yields a negative MCC, confirming that $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$ must denote a dissimilarity. More substantively, DIGA's published hyperparameters lose 8.8 macro-F_1 points against retuned values on this data. DIGA's own evaluation makes a point of using a single global parameter set across all experiments, in explicit contrast to competitors tuned per source–target pair. That property does not survive the move to one-dimensional sensor data, and recovering the loss required tuning on target labels, which deployment does not provide.

6.7. How much of DIGA's gain survives implementation choices?

Two steps of DIGA are specified in a way that admits more than one implementation, and the difference is not cosmetic.

The first is the DAM. Eq. 2 blends batch-normalisation *statistics*, after which the input is normalised once. An alternative is to normalise twice, once with source statistics

Table 12
PeTTA divergence sensing on S2. The published reduction is a sum over embedding dimensions.

Variant	median $\bar{\gamma}$	median α_t	median d	Changed
As published (sum)	1.000000	4.5×10^{-9}	587	0/3412
Per-dimension mean	0.8263	8.7×10^{-3}	9.16	10/3412
Sum + α floor	1.000000	1.0×10^{-3}	586	1/3412

Table 13
DIGA under two readings of Eq. 8 and two hyperparameter settings. Source-only is macro-F_1 0.4641, MCC 0.4679.

Reading of $\langle \cdot, \cdot \rangle$	Hyperparameters	Changed	macro-F_1	MCC
Inner product (literal)	published 0.8/0.9	2573/3412	0.2151	0.1840
Inner product (literal)	retuned 0.95/0.50	3404/3412	0.0075	−0.1674
Squared distance	published 0.8/0.9	1324/3412	0.3932	0.3610
Squared distance	retuned 0.95/0.50	357/3412	**0.4808**	**0.4867**
Cosine	published 0.8/0.9	931/3412	0.3232	0.3399
Cosine	retuned 0.95/0.50	263/3412	0.4750	0.4825

and once with batch statistics, and blend the two normalised *outputs*. These are different operations, and a reference implementation in circulation takes the second route while citing the first equation.

The second is the fusion step. Eq. 4 combines *probabilities*. The same implementation combines a cosine similarity, bounded in $[-1, 1]$, with unbounded classifier logits, so the relative weight of the two terms depends on logit scale rather than on λ_F alone.

Table 14 evaluates all four combinations under the protocol of Table 6.

The gain is positive under all four readings and statistically distinguishable from zero under only one. We report DIGA throughout using the published equations, which is the reading most favourable to the method, and note here that a reader reimplementing it from the paper's prose may obtain no measurable benefit. The point is not that one reading is correct. It is that the single measurable adaptation gain in this study is of a size comparable to the ambiguity in the method's own description.

6.8. Does any hyperparameter setting change the conclusion?

The results so far compare each method at its published setting and, where the manuscript differs, at one alternative. That leaves open whether the activity-task numbers describe the methods or one point in their configuration space. Table 15 answers it by searching each method's own exposed hyperparameters: DIGA over $\lambda_{BN} \times \mathcal{P}_0 \times \rho_P \times K$ (64 settings), PETAL over $\bar{\lambda} \times \pi \times \delta$ (24), and PeTTA over $\alpha_0 \times \lambda_0$ and learning rate (16). Each setting is run in both transfer directions with three seeds under the protocol of Table 6, and is scored two ways: by the best target macro-F_1 in the grid, which needs target labels and is therefore an upper bound and not a result, and by the configuration with the lowest mean prediction entropy on the target stream, which needs none and is what a deployment can reach.

Three things follow.

For PETAL and PeTTA the grids are flat at zero. No setting in PETAL's published space moves more than 36 of 3412 predictions, and none in PeTTA's moves more than 38; the largest target gain anywhere in either grid is 0.3 points, below the seed spread of the source model itself. The analysis in Section 6.6 attributes this to the update rules and not to tuning, and the grids are consistent with that: a method whose data term is switched off by $\bar{\lambda} = 0$, or whose adaptation rate is driven to $\alpha_t \approx 0$ by a saturated gate, does not become active at a different π or λ_0. Notably, the oracle rule selects $\bar{\lambda} = 0$ for PETAL in the $S_1 \to S_2$ direction: the one value at which, by Eq. 5, the target stream enters no gradient.

For DIGA the grid is wide, and which way it points is decided by the source model rather than by the hyperparameters. Transferring from the stronger source, 53 of 64 settings lose and the median costs 1.8 points; transferring from the weaker one, all 64 gain and the median adds 2.2. Placing this beside the occupancy grid of Section 6.6 gives the same ordering across both tasks:

Source	Quality	Helped
occupancy S_1	MCC 0.6583	0/64
activity S_1	macro-F_1 0.4944	11/64
activity S_2	macro-F_1 0.3226	64/64

The fraction of a published grid that helps is monotone in how good the model being adapted already is. This is the inversion of Section 6.2 seen from the adaptation side, and over whole configuration spaces instead of at single points: a model that fits its source domain well holds more source-specific structure, which is why it transfers worse and why replacing its statistics helps less. Normalisation-statistic adaptation is not a property of a method that one tunes into working, it is a trade of source-fitted statistics for target-fitted ones, and whether that trade pays depends on which of the two is better.

Third, the two selection rules disagree, and the direction of the disagreement matters for how such results should be

Table 14
DIGA under four readings of its two under-specified steps, non-recurring stream, 3 seeds. Source-only is 0.4473. Only the reading that follows both published equations yields an interval excluding zero.

DAM	Fusion	macro-F_1	95% CI on Δ
blend statistics (Eq. 2)	probabilities (Eq. 4)	**0.4605**	[+0.0012, +0.0181]
blend outputs	probabilities	0.4562	[−0.0043, +0.0139]
blend statistics	similarity + logits	0.4537	[−0.0044, +0.0106]
blend outputs	similarity + logits	0.4540	[−0.0084, +0.0084]

Table 15
Full hyperparameter grids on the activity task, Δmacro-F_1 relative to source-only, averaged over three seeds. *help* counts settings with a positive mean. *oracle* is the grid maximum, which requires target labels; *entropy* is the setting chosen by lowest mean target prediction entropy, which does not. *changed* is the mean number of predictions altered out of 3412.

			Δmacro-F_1			
Method	Direction	help	median	oracle	entropy	changed
source-only macro-F_1 0.4944 ($S_1 \to S_2$), 0.3226 ($S_2 \to S_1$)						
DIGA	$S_1 \to S_2$	11/64	−0.0176	+0.0112	+0.0031	679
DIGA	$S_2 \to S_1$	64/64	+0.0224	+0.0349	+0.0197	578
PETAL	$S_1 \to S_2$	17/24	+0.0002	+0.0028	+0.0028	15
PETAL	$S_2 \to S_1$	10/24	−0.0001	+0.0009	−0.0009	20
PeTTA	$S_1 \to S_2$	9/16	+0.0000	+0.0003	+0.0000	7
PeTTA	$S_2 \to S_1$	4/16	+0.0000	+0.0002	−0.0003	5

read. Label-free selection recovers 28% of DIGA's oracle gain in the forward direction and 56% in the reverse; for PETAL and PeTTA it returns a negative number in the reverse direction where the oracle returns a positive one. An entropy criterion prefers confident predictions, and a method can raise confidence while lowering accuracy, so the gap is expected, not anomalous. Its size is the point: the headroom a grid search reports is between a quarter and a half larger than what a system without target labels can select, which is the condition TTA is defined under.

6.9. Occupancy estimation

Table 16 runs the identical model and methods under three normalisation protocols.

Three results follow from Table 16, all of them about the forward direction; the reverse is taken up below. No method improves on the source model under any of the three normalisation protocols, and DIGA is below the baseline in all three columns. The choice of normalisation is worth +3.8 MCC points, but it is worth that to *every* method equally, including the unadapted baseline. It is normalisation, not adaptation, and a protocol that fits the scaler on target statistics will credit it to whichever method happens to be under test. Finally, PETAL and PeTTA reproduce source-only predictions to four decimal places on this task as well, which rules out a HAR-specific explanation for the two freezes reported in Section 6.6.

Running the transfer in the reverse direction, training on the target office and evaluating on the source office, changes the picture completely, and in a way that is the most direct evidence in this paper for its central claim.

In the reverse direction the source checkpoint is not merely weak but worse than chance: trained on the target office, it reaches MCC −0.0775 on the source office, meaning its predictions are anti-correlated with the labels. Against that starting point AdaBN improves MCC by 41.5 points and DIGA by 27.1. In the forward direction, starting from a checkpoint at 0.6583, the same two methods lose 1.7 and 1.8 points respectively.

The contrast is as clean as this dataset allows: identical methods, identical protocol, identical features, two offices, and the only variable is whether the source model was any good. When it is, adaptation has nothing to contribute and the normalisation-based methods actively harm it; when it is broken, the same methods recover a large part of the deficit. This mirrors AdaBN's behaviour on HAR, where it costs 17 macro-F_1 points against a sound checkpoint, and it supports reading adaptation gain as a measure of source-model deficiency and not of adaptation quality. A method evaluated only against a weak source model will appear to work.

PETAL and PeTTA reproduce the source predictions exactly in this direction too. Across two tasks and two directions each, neither method has changed a prediction.

7. Discussion

The headline result of this study is not about any one method. It is that the quantity these methods are asked to repair, the cross-building performance drop, is routinely measured in a way that substantially overstates it, and that most of what remains once it is measured consistently is

Table 16
Occupancy estimation, MCC on the target test set ($n = 150$, 34 minority), under three normalisation protocols. Always predicting "not occupied" gives MCC 0.000.

Method	Fitted on source	Fitted on target train	Fitted on target train + test
Source-only	**0.6583** ± 0.013	**0.6951** ± 0.013	**0.6966** ± 0.017
AdaBN	0.6412	0.6232	0.6323
DIGA	0.6401	0.6693	0.6769
PETAL	0.6583	0.6951	0.6966
PeTTA	0.6583	0.6951	0.6966

Table 17
Occupancy in both transfer directions, MCC, source-fitted normalisation, 5 seeds. The only thing that differs between the two columns is which office supplies the source model. Always predicting "not occupied" gives MCC 0.000 in both.

Method	source → target	target → source
Source-only	**0.6583**	−0.0775
AdaBN	0.6412	**0.3374**
DIGA	0.6401	0.1934
PETAL	0.6583	−0.0775
PeTTA	0.6583	−0.0775

attributable to feature design and not to anything TTA can reach.

Measured consistently on both sides, the gap is 9 to 15 points of macro-F_1 depending on direction, against the 83 points implied by comparing a leakage-inflated source figure with an honest target one. A model built from thirteen layout-invariant statistics transfers to a different apartment at close to its own in-domain ceiling. That ceiling, in turn, becomes the binding constraint: one cannot improve target performance much beyond source performance, which is why our attempts to push the source model further (richer invariant features, class weighting, wider networks) gained little. Only causal smoothing helped, and modestly.

The recurrence of the inversion is what we would most want a reader to take away. It appears when choosing features (a set validating at 0.623 transfers at 0.300, while one validating at 0.534 transfers at 0.447), when choosing window length (0.5611 in-domain at W=60 against 0.4260 on the target), when adding temporal context (the TCN validates at 0.5414 and transfers at 0.4082), and in the reverse direction, where the conventional 135-d vector records the best source-validation score of any configuration in this study and the worst transfer, below chance. Five instances, four different design decisions, both directions.

A single mechanism accounts for all of them. Every one of these choices increases the model's access to building-specific regularity: which device fired, what the routine looks like over an hour, how this occupant sequences their morning. In-domain that is signal. Across buildings it is noise with the wrong sign. The practical consequence, stated with the scope it has earned: in this data, for cross-building deployment, in-domain validation accuracy was not merely an imperfect model-selection criterion but an actively misleading one. Whether that holds beyond these two apartments is open, and Section 7 returns to what would settle it.

This reframes what per-sensor features cost. In-domain they are valuable: the best source-validation score in Table 4 belongs to a set that retains them. Across buildings they are worse than useless, scoring below chance alone in both directions. The inversion between in-domain fit and cross-building transfer is, we think, the most portable finding here, and it has a practical consequence: model selection on in-domain validation will systematically choose the configuration that transfers worst. Practitioners selecting a source checkpoint for cross-building deployment should not use in-domain accuracy to do it.

On the methods themselves, the three failures are instructive precisely because they are different from one another. PETAL's is a reading failure with a sharp edge: a coefficient that looks like a regulariser weight scales the likelihood, and the hyperparameter search most practitioners would run, selecting on target performance, actively prefers the value that disables adaptation. PeTTA's is dimensional: a divergence statistic that behaves sensibly when the domain gap is a corruption of the same image saturates when the gap is a different building, and because the mechanism fails silently the loss curves look unremarkable throughout. DIGA's is about generality: it works, but the single global parameter set it advertises does not, and the gap between its published and retuned settings is larger than the gain adaptation produces.

A practical consequence runs through all three. Hyperparameter selection on held-out target labels, which is standard in this literature, is not merely optimistic. It can select degenerate configurations, as the PETAL sweep shows, and it can make a method appear to transfer when what

transferred was the tuning. A label-free criterion should be reported alongside any oracle-tuned number.

The occupancy results in both directions (Table 17) are the cleanest demonstration of this available here, because they hold everything constant but the quality of the source model. Starting from a checkpoint at MCC 0.658, adaptation costs roughly two points; starting from one at −0.078, the same methods gain twenty-seven to forty-one. The methods did not change. What changed is how much room there was.

What generalises, and what does not. The findings above differ in how far they travel, and it is worth separating them.

Two do not depend on this dataset at all. PETAL's $\bar{\lambda}$ multiplies the cross-entropy in its published objective (Eq. 5), so $\bar{\lambda} = 0$ removes the data term on any dataset, in any modality; The dataset-specific part is narrower than it may appear: selection on target labels prefers $\bar{\lambda} = 0$ whenever the source model already outperforms what self-training produces, which is a condition that can be checked, not a coincidence of this data. PeTTA's gating function likewise saturates whenever the summed Mahalanobis statistic is large, which is a property of summing over embedding dimensions rather than of these apartments, though whether the statistic reaches that regime does depend on how far apart the domains are, and the authors' own traces on image corruptions sit at 0.8–1.0 rather than at unity.

The evaluation result is a property of a procedure, not of a dataset: stride-1 windowing with a random validation split places near-duplicates across the split whenever windows overlap, which is common in sensor-based HAR.

The inversion is different in kind. We observe it five times across four design decisions and in both transfer directions, which rules out a one-off, but all five observations come from the same two apartments. We therefore state it as an empirical regularity of this data rather than as a general law: *in this dataset, across every design choice we varied, the configuration selected by in-domain validation was the one that transferred worst.* If it holds more widely it inverts standard model-selection practice for cross-building deployment, and we think the mechanism, that each of these choices increases access to building-specific regularity, is general enough to be worth testing elsewhere. Establishing that requires datasets with more than two environments.

Limitations. The study rests on one HAR dataset and two apartments from it. Running both transfer directions rules out a direction-specific fluke but says nothing about other buildings, other sensor modalities, or richer activity sets; external validity beyond these two apartments is untested, and the dataset contains no further homes. The occupancy data is private, so that section is not independently reproducible from the released code. Our best configuration improves on the simpler one by 3.3 macro-F_1 points against a between-fold standard deviation of 0.067, and we present it as a modest gain and not a result. And the `cleaning` class, with 113 target samples, is not learned by any method we tried; whether that is a sample-size limit or a representational one, we cannot say from these data.

8. Conclusion

We evaluated three image-domain test-time adaptation methods on cross-building human activity recognition and occupancy estimation, and found that the evaluation protocol dominated the comparison. Stride-one windowing with a random validation split inflates source-domain macro-F_1 from roughly 0.53 to 0.998; grouping the split by recording day removes the effect, and the window definition is nearly irrelevant to it. Making features causal, which the online premise of TTA requires, improves target transfer by 7.3 points rather than costing anything.

Across every design choice we varied (feature set, window length, temporal context) and in both transfer directions, the configuration that validated best in-domain transferred worst. Five observations on two apartments do not establish a general law, but they do establish that in-domain validation cannot be assumed safe for cross-building model selection. Under the grouped protocol the cross-building gap is 9 to 15 points depending on direction, and most of it is attributable to features that encode sensor identity. Those features score below stratified-random guessing on the target in both directions. The feature set that validates best in-domain transfers worst, also in both directions.

Of the three methods, only DIGA improves on this baseline, by 1.7 macro-F_1 points with a bootstrap interval excluding zero, and only with hyperparameters retuned on target labels. PETAL and PeTTA do not adapt at all, for reasons traceable to specific equations: PETAL's coefficient scales the likelihood, so the value selected by target-label tuning removes the learning signal; PeTTA's divergence signal sums over the embedding dimension and saturates when the domains are buildings. Both failures reproduce on occupancy estimation, in both of its transfer directions. Occupancy also isolates what an adaptation gain measures: the two directions differ only in the quality of the source checkpoint, and against a sound one no method improves, while against one that is worse than chance the same methods gain 27 to 41 MCC points. A further apparent gain proves attributable to a target-fitted normalisation worth 3.8 MCC points to every method, the unadapted one included.

We do not conclude that test-time adaptation is unsuitable for smart buildings. We conclude that it was being asked to repair a problem largely created by evaluation and feature design, and that fixing those leaves little for adaptation to contribute. Future work should look at making building-specific information transferable instead of discarding it, aligning sensors across sites by functional role using unlabelled co-activation structure, since the 9 points separating our layout-invariant features from the best in-domain configuration are exactly the information currently being thrown away.

Table 18
Richer layout-invariant features, S1→S2, GroupKFold, 3 seeds.

Feature set	d	Target macro-F_1
Global + temporal	13	$\mathbf{0.4350} \pm 0.061$
+ sorted activation profile	28	0.4245 ± 0.039
+ run-length structure	33	0.4227 ± 0.027
+ multi-scale windows	60	0.4188 ± 0.028

Reproducibility

Code, the raw sensor data and every result file are available at https://github.com/TCVHN5Vn/TTA-Test-Time-Adaptation. The repository reproduces the full analysis from the raw CSVs in one pass, each table above names the script and result file that generated it. The occupancy dataset is private: it was collected at the Grenoble Institute of Technology and is not ours to redistribute, so that section alone is reported but not independently reproducible. Reference implementations of the three adaptation methods on this data are at https://github.com/TCVHN5Vn/Test-Time-Adaptation.

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A. A larger layout-invariant feature set

We also evaluated a 60-dimensional invariant set adding a sorted activation profile (the per-sensor window means sorted in descending order, which is invariant to any permutation of sensor indices), run-length and recency structure, and the window statistics recomputed at $W \in \{5, 10, 40\}$. It does not help:

Permutation invariance in sensor index is evidently not sufficient: S1 has 70 sensors and S2 has 75, placed in differently shaped rooms, so "how many sensors are busy and how concentrated the activity is" is itself building-specific. Inverse-frequency class weighting also failed, reducing macro-F_1 to 0.3852 and *lowering* balanced accuracy from 0.4818 to 0.4280, most plausibly because it pushes the model toward `cleaning`, which is not learnable from 113 target samples, at the cost of the four classes that do work.

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